(Sir Alex Ferguson, manager of Manchester United Football Club)

This book is aimed at a general readership, though, hopefully, it will interest students of Cold War nuclear history, including those with a specific concern with the Cuban missile crisis. It provides details of events and outlines key debates about the crisis. It is for the reader to reach their own verdicts on history and make up their own minds about lessons that might be drawn from the crisis. Which details are provided, and how debates are framed, reflect, of course, the author's assumptions and perspectives. And one such assumption is that good luck was absolutely essential in the prevention of nuclear war in 1962.

Questions are also identified where answers remain unknown or unclear. The history of the crisis is strewn with puzzles and conundrums. There are, moreover, secrets still hidden and mysteries that will never be solved. And there are things that we do not know that we do not know. This book identifies some of the puzzles, conundrums, secrets, and mysteries. And it explains where understanding has changed as new information and interpretation emerged.

Some basic questions of why the crisis began, and how it ended, still generate disagreement among historians and other scholars. One of the most striking aspects of the crisis is how events crucial to our understanding of the risk of nuclear war have only emerged, forty, fifty or indeed over sixty years on.

Behind these aims lie the challenges of what lessons we can learn from the crisis for the conduct of international relations in the nuclear age. To put it simply, if we want to learn lessons, we need to know what happened, why, and with what consequences. If we are mistaken in what we know, or our knowledge is insufficient, we may well draw the wrong conclusion. If current judgements reflect verdicts of history, we need to acknowledge that the jury often gets called back to revisit their decisions.

In 1986 Eliot Cohen argued that 'The Cuban Missile crisis is and will remain singularly unrepresentative of post-war crises, and it offers precious little historical guidance for American statesmen today.'[4] In March 1987